night,' wrote Heinz Lippmann, 'I witnessed the first quarrel between Margot Feist and Erich Honecker, when he tried to justify this resolution as necessary.'4 Sometime between eight and nine, Erich Honecker was back on the streets rallying 600 blue-shirted FDJers to stage a pro-Government counterdemonstration. Armed with a loudhailer, he arranged a quick rehearsal before the group hoisted banners declaring: 'I have confidence in our government,' and marched off down Stalin Allee singing patriotic songs, following the route taken earlier by the strikers. By nightfall, the disturbances had calmed as demonstrators prepared for a general strike.

In the small hours of 17 June, Walter Ulbricht took his entourage – including Erich and Margot – to shelter at the Soviet military headquarters in Karlshorst, the same place where Germany's unconditional surrender was signed in 1945. Couped up in the canteen, they sat restlessly preparing to follow events with a phone and transistor radio. Karl Schirdewan, second only to Ulbricht in the national hierarchy – had clear memories of Ulbricht and Grotewohl lingering over small talk and tea, 'nobody made any decisions. I thought the Party was leaderless.'

Then as the sun poked through storm clouds, workers began marching from outlying districts toward the House of Ministries. Across the GDR, similar marches got underway in Halle, Leipzig, Dresden, Gera, Merseburg and Görlitz. Along with SED and FDJ lackeys, police officials tried – and mostly failed – to encourage the marchers to return to their homes and workplaces. However, by 09.10, over 25,000 people had congregated in front of the House of Ministries, and tens of thousands more were en route to Leipziger Straße or in Potsdamer Platz.

As the crowds grew in Berlin, events took an ugly turn when around 100 demonstrators overpowered police at the House of Ministries. As all hell broke out, protestors attacked the entrance, breaking windows, throwing in burning pieces of wood, and battering the doors. Bruce Rothwell, a journalist from the Daily News, reported that: 'books by Marx, Engels, Stalin and Lenin were burned in street bonfires. Fire brigades turned hoses on the packed crowds – but in vain, they were already soaked from the rain.'5 Over the coming hours, kiosks were overturned, and the red flag was torn down from the Brandenburg Gate and set alight.